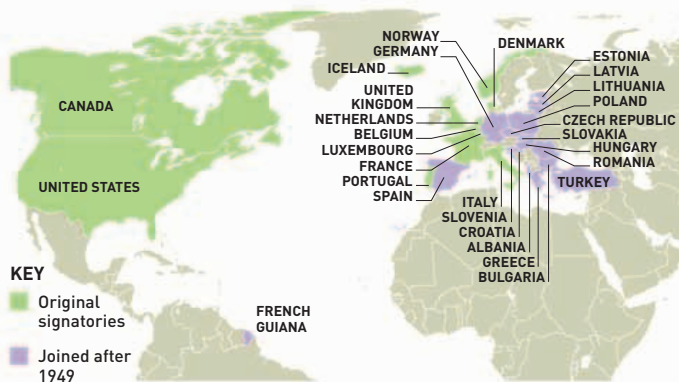


“...A ROOF STRETCHING OVER THE ATLANTIC OCEAN.”

Ernest Bevin, British foreign secretary, describing the North Atlantic Treaty

At the signing of the North Atlantic Treaty in Washington, D.C., on April 4, US president Harry S. Truman gave an address on its significance.



A TRUCE WAS REACHED IN THE ARAB-ISRAELI WAR (see 1948), bringing an end to eight months of hostilities. The Israelis referred to it as their “**War of Independence**,” while the Arabs called it “*Al Naqba*,” or “**The Catastrophe**.” The Arab states negotiated separate armistice agreements. Egypt was the first to sign on February 24, followed by Lebanon, Jordan, and Syria. The agreement established a line between Israel and the Jordanian-held West Bank, which became known as the **Green Line**.

Representatives of Belgium, Britain, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, and the US met in Washington, D.C., in April, to sign an historic treaty that established the **North Atlantic Treaty Organization**, or **NATO**. The alliance was intended for **mutual defense**; countries promised to develop their capacity to resist armed attack, and to consult one another when any of the countries was

NATO alliance

This map illustrates the 12 nations that originally signed up to NATO in 1949. The alliance enabled the US to keep military bases in Europe.

threatened. The treaty also provided that member countries would try to **settle disputes by peaceful means**.

The **Soviet Union** stunned the West by exploding its **first atomic bomb**, on August 29, at a remote test site in Kazakhstan. Named “**First Lightning**,” its development was facilitated by US spies, such as Julius and Ethel Rosenberg, and British spy Donald Maclean, who had passed technological secrets to the Soviets (see 1951). The loss of nuclear supremacy led US president Harry Truman to order the development of the much more powerful **hydrogen bomb**.

The **Berlin Airlift** (see 1948) by the Western Allies had aided solidarity with the West German leaders. On May 23, the western occupied zones were united to form the **Federal Republic of**

Germany. West Germany held the first free elections since 1932, and the Christian Democrats under **Dr. Konrad Adenauer** (1876–1967) won a small majority.

In July, the Vatican issued the **Acta Apostolicae Sedis** under Pope Pius XII, which effectively **excommunicated Catholics** who collaborated with or supported the Communist Party. The decree represented a significant counteroffensive by the Holy See in a **religious Cold War** against the communist regime, following the persecution of Catholics in communist states.

On Easter Monday, April 18, Eire became the **Republic of Ireland**, following the bill of 1938. It meant Ireland had officially broken free of allegiance to the British crown. In May, the British Parliament approved a bill continuing the status of Northern Ireland as a part of Great Britain; six northern Irish counties had shown a majority in favour of remaining British in the **Northern Ireland General Election** held on February 19.

The **Fourth Geneva Convention** was adopted in August. It brought together the elements of the previous three Geneva Conventions of 1864, 1906, and 1929, and added rules to protect civilians during war. It came in response to **Nazi atrocities** during World War II and the practice of “total war.” The international treaty governed the **treatment of civilians during wartime**, including hostages, diplomats, spies, bystanders, and civilians in territory under military occupation.

Civil war in China (see 1946) drew to an end in 1949. Beijing was taken by the communists and its name changed back to **Beijing**, and between April and November, most major cities passed to communist control with minimal resistance. **Mao Zedong** (see 1921) proclaimed the founding of the **People's Republic of China** on October 1, and in December, Chiang Kai-shek and his Nationalist troops fled from the mainland to the island of Formosa (Taiwan), naming **Taipei** the **temporary capital of China**.

The Dutch finally gave up their struggle over **Indonesia** in

December and conceded independence after four years of war. **President Ahmed Sukarno** (1901–70), who had cooperated with the Japanese in the war, emerged as the strongest national leader; he was faced with the task of welding all the separate regions into a **united nation** under a new constitution, with **Jakarta** as the capital of the Republic. On September 26, 1950, Indonesia was **admitted to the UN** (see 1965).

New **7-inch vinyl records** (also called 45s) were introduced in the US by record company RCA on January 10.

With its format of one song per side, the “**single**” was perfect for rock ‘n’ roll, and it went on to revolutionize the **pop music business**. In the first year of production, RCA pressed more than **25 million 45s**.



People's Republic
Following the proclamation of the **People's Republic of China**, propaganda posters showed a smiling Chairman Mao Zedong encouraging his people to build a new, prosperous country.

